

Structuring a codebase so an *agent* can be trusted in it

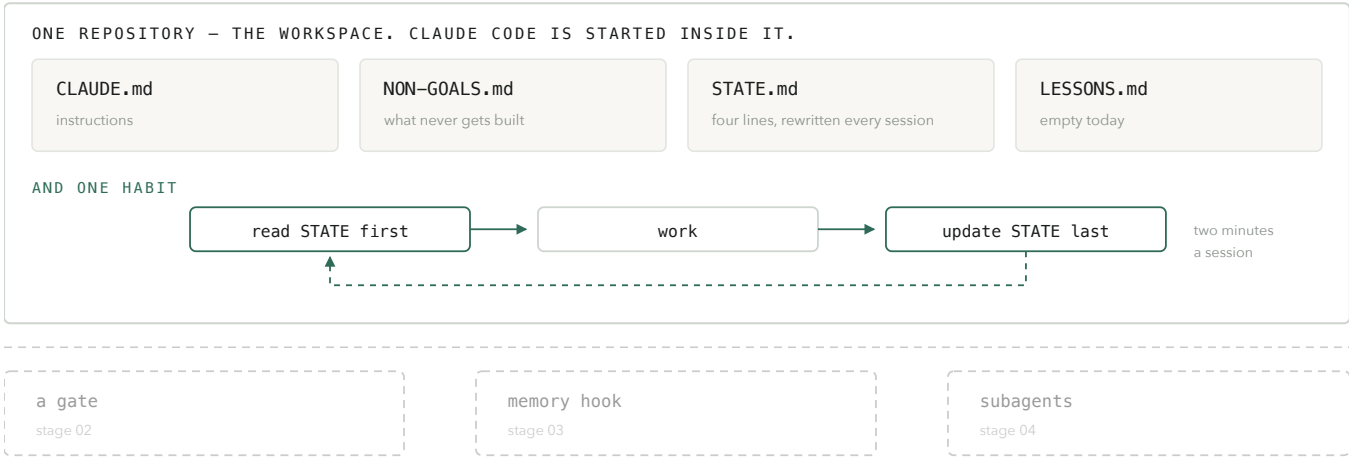
Four files, one habit, and a rule about when to build anything more. This is the minimum that makes an agent start warm, stay inside its lane, and stop claiming work it never ran — and a build order that lets the next failure, not this document, decide what comes next.

read STATE first → work → update STATE last · two minutes a session

"Read this. Build stage 1 only. Then stop and tell me what you built."

01 The build order

THE CORE



BUILT LATER, EACH AFTER ITS OWN FAILURE

FIG. 1 – THE CORE IS FOUR FILES AND ONE HABIT. THE REST IS OPTIONAL AND STAYS THAT WAY UNTIL SOMETHING BREAKS.

STAGE	01 THE CORE	02 ONE GATE	03 MEMORY	04 SUBAGENTS	05 UNATTENDED WORK	06 MEASURE YOURSELF
Trigger	you are using an agent on something you care about	a rule in CLAUDE.md has been ignored once	you have re-explained the same context twice	one session no longer has room to both build and judge	you want work done while not watching	you wrote a number about your own system by hand
Cost	an afternoon	an hour	half a day	a day	days	hours
You get	an agent that starts warm, stays inside the repo, and cannot quietly claim to be finished	one rule that can no longer be forgotten – by you or the agent	sessions that start warm; lessons that outlive the session that learned them	work done in parallel, and a main session that can still say no	work done while you are not watching, on a branch you can throw away	a description of your own system that you can check instead of believe

You will recognise yourself in what you notice, not in the mechanisms

WHAT YOU NOTICE	WHICH STAGE
The agent starts every session knowing nothing and you explain the project again	stage 03
It reports "done" on work it never ran	stage 01 the habit, then 02 the gate
It built a dashboard, a config layer and four folders nobody asked for	stage 01 the non-goals
It read, or wrote, far outside the project	stage 01 the boundary, then 02
The same fact lives in two files and they disagree	stage 01 – status never in CLAUDE.md
Your main session is so full it can no longer judge its own output	stage 04
A rule that used to hold quietly stopped holding	stage 02 – it was a habit, not a gate
You cannot tell if what you are reading about the system is measured or remembered	stage 06

A **gate** is enforced by the machinery; forgetting it is impossible. A **habit** is held only by routine, and habits fail silently – that is their defining property. Build gates for the rules that have already bitten you. Accept the rest as habits, knowingly.